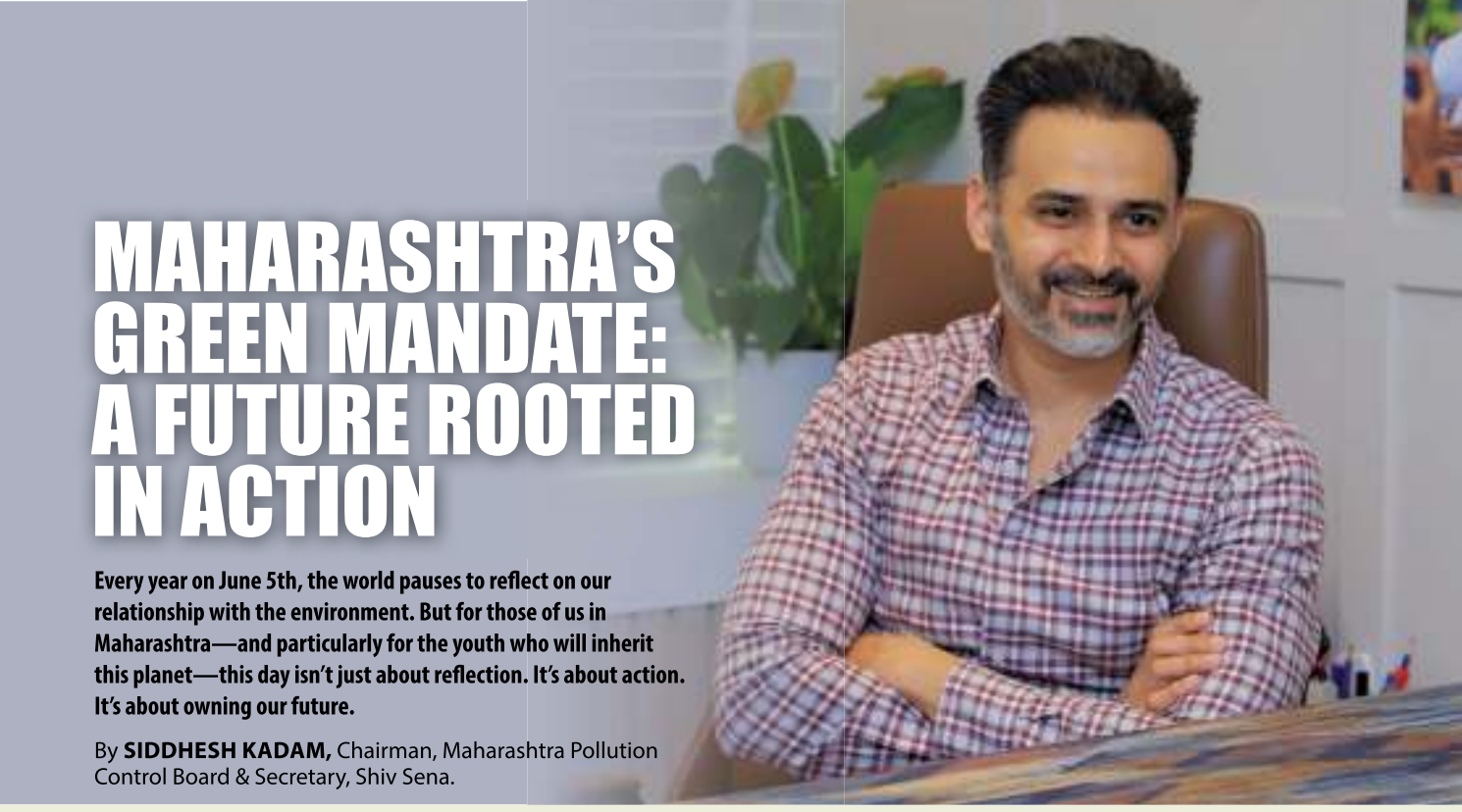


MAHARASHTRA'S GREEN MANDATE: A FUTURE ROOTED IN ACTION

Every year on June 5th, the world pauses to reflect on our relationship with the environment. But for those of us in Maharashtra—and particularly for the youth who will inherit this planet—this day isn't just about reflection. It's about action. It's about owning our future.

By **SIDDHESH KADAM,** Chairman, Maharashtra Pollution Control Board & Secretary, Shiv Sena.

Last month, during one of my college visits, a student in Pune asked me directly: "Sir, why should we believe that this generation of leaders will solve climate change when previous generations created this mess?" Her question was blunt, honest, but fair. It's the kind of straight talk I respect, and frankly, it's the kind of accountability every leader needs to face.

Here's my answer to her, and to every young Maharashtrian reading this: We won't solve this crisis for you. We'll solve it with you.

Maharashtra's Environmental DNA

Maharashtra has always been a pioneer. In 1969, before India had a national water pollution law, Maharashtra enacted its own Water Prevention Act. In 2018, while other states debated, we banned single-use plastics. Three years later, the entire country followed our lead.

This isn't political chest-thumping. This is about understanding Maharashtra's character. We are a state that believes in action over words and results over rhetoric. From Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj's forward-thinking governance to the industrial revolution that shaped modern India, Maharashtra has never shied away from bold decisions.

But here's what's different about today's environmental challenge: it's the first crisis in human history that can only be solved by the next generation taking charge now, not later.

The Youth Revolution We Need

I've spent considerable time visiting colleges across Maharashtra, from engineering institutions in Pune to agricultural universities in Marathwada. What I've discovered is extraordinary: young Maharashtrians aren't just concerned about the environment; they're frustrated by the pace of change and hungry for real responsibility.

Today's youth possess something my generation didn't have at their age, access to information, technology, and global networks that can accelerate environmental solutions. They're digital natives who think in terms of systems, not silos. They understand that environmental challenges are interconnected with economic opportunity, social justice, and technological innovation.

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But here's what concerns me: we're still treating them as beneficiaries of our policies rather than architects of solutions. We invite them to seminars to listen, not to board rooms to decide. We ask them to implement our ideas, not to challenge our assumptions.

The innovation is happening. The passion is real. What's missing is the platform to scale these ideas and the political will to empower young leaders with real decision-making authority.

As someone who represents both environmental governance and political leadership, I have a responsibility to bridge this gap. The Shiv Sena has always believed in empowering people at the grassroots level. Today, that empowerment must extend to environmental action, with youth not just participating, but leading the charge.

Beyond Compliance: A Movement

MPCB launched our "100 Days Program"—focused interventions including inventorying e-waste, cleaning polluted river stretches, upgrading solid waste management, enhancing public awareness, and strengthening complaint redressal.

Our Mahaparyavaran App isn't just a complaint portal—it's a platform where citizens can register complaints and suggestions while receiving pollution alerts. This digital bridge empowers communities to contribute meaningfully to environmental protection.

The Namami Panchganga initiative focuses on river rejuvenation through improved sewage treatment, real-time water quality monitoring, and community-based water management. The Chandrabhaga River Action Plan follows a similar holistic approach—mapping pollution sources, assessing STPs, examining industrial discharge, and emphasising citizen awareness.

During our urban pollution strategy consultations in Nagpur, Nashik, Kolhapur, and Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, we've involved NGOs, industries, and educational institutions to understand site-specific challenges.

This isn't tokenism. This is transformation.

The Circular Economy Opportunity

Our district-wise circular economy directory maps over 1,200 units across the state managing battery waste, tyre waste, plastics, e-waste, used oil, solvents, and metal scraps. We're promoting industries to think beyond disposal through waste-to-wealth solutions and co-processing in cement kilns.

Our strategic partnerships with colleges aim to foster environmental innovation among students and faculty, leading to practical solutions for air, water, and waste management challenges.

As a Shiv Sena leader, I see this as fulfilling our core promise: creating opportunities for Maharashtrians, by Maharashtrians. When young entrepreneurs develop innovative recycling solutions, they're building Maharashtra's next economic boom.

Technology as an Enabler, Not a Crutch

MPCB is implementing AI-enabled compliance monitoring systems across highly polluting